

Examining information

Every day, hundreds of thousands of articles are shared online. With so many claims made about everything from the NASA Moon landings to current events, it is increasingly difficult to evaluate and understand what to take as fact and what to discard as fiction. Information online may be wrong on purpose, by mistake, or be opinion passed off as fact. Here are some tips that may help when scrutinizing online information.

REAL WORLD

Snopes

Snopes.com is one of the most respected websites for sorting fact from fiction. It was set up in 1994 to investigate and fact-check online information. If you want to find out the truth behind a particular story you've seen online, it is worth searching Snopes to see if there is an article on there covering it.

Purpose

Most sites have an "About this site" section that explains the website's angle. This is an invaluable source of information as it usually explains if the site is to be taken seriously, if it has a particular ideological angle, who the target audience is, and who writes for the site.

Who hosts the site?

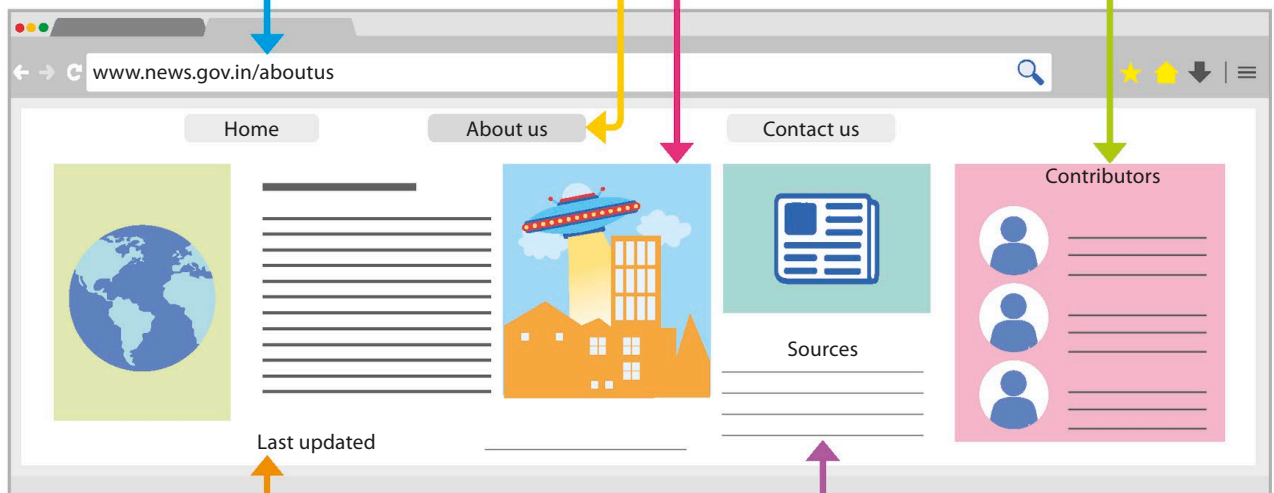
"gov" sites are governmental websites and are officially approved information. "edu" sites are usually from educational authorities, or opinion sites by students. "org" sites are organizations, and every one is different. "com" sites are usually commercial sites.

Bias

The majority of websites have a bias: a particular ideological view – be it political, religious, or economic. Sites that have a bias are more likely to be selective in what they cover, omit things that don't fit into their view, and tend more towards opinion than fact.

Reputation

Use a search engine to see what others have to say about a particular site and its writers. As anyone can put information online, checking on an author's credentials should establish if they are a recognized voice on a particular subject.



Up-to-date

Most sites show when a particular piece of information was uploaded. While this may not be so important for sites giving general information on something, it is crucial for news sites, where having out-of-date information is the same as having wrong information.

Sources

Sites that provide links to their sources – be they weblinks (sometimes included as hyperlinks in the body of the site) or lists of books, or films – help to give the reader more context and show that the ideas on the site are the product of investigation and consideration.